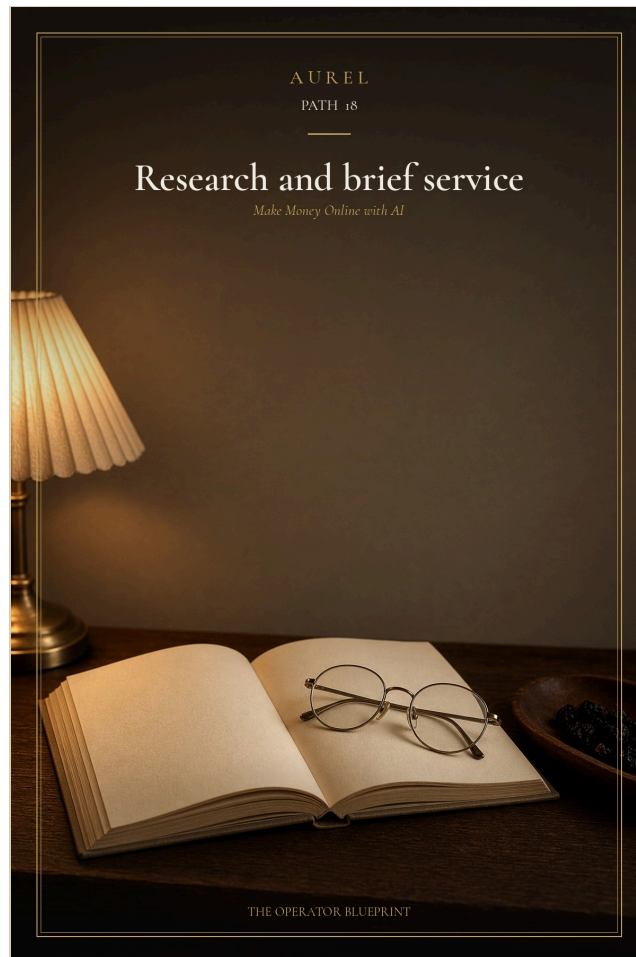




PATH 18

Research and brief service

A messy question in. A two-page brief out. You verify what the model cannot know.

16 minute read · 3,546 words

Who this is for

You can turn a pile of tabs into a decision someone can use.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One paid brief delivered on time.

Cash window

\$150–\$600 per brief

Leave this alone

Docs, a simple order form, sources you will and will not use.

Claiming ‘AI knows everything.’ Publishing unreviewed facts.

What this actually is

Anyone can paste a question into a model. What they get back is a confident first draft with a unknown number of invented citations. You sell something narrower: a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What you found, what you verified, what is still unknown, and a recommended next step. One revision included.

The product is judgment. The model is a junior researcher who works fast and lies when bored. You are the person who says which numbers can stand in a meeting.

What a brief is not It is not a white paper. It is not a twelve-page literature review. It is not “I’ll go deep on your whole market.” Executives do not read twelve pages. Operators do not need a seminar. They need a decision, on a date, with the holes labeled.

Why two pages Two pages forces you to choose. If a finding cannot earn a sentence, it does not belong. The “do not know” section is not a cop-out. It is the part that makes the rest believable. People who have been burned by a hallucinated source will pay for someone who will write “I could not verify this” in plain type.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if people already ask you “what should I do about X?” and you already open twenty tabs before you answer. You can tell a primary source from a blog that copied a blog. You can say “I do not know” without feeling like you failed.

You can do this if - You have a niche where you already know the landscape: a trade, a software category, a local market, a regulation you have had to live

with. - You can write two tight pages in a working day after the sweep. - You will check the citations. Not some of them. The ones you present as fact.

Skip this path if Skip it if you want to publish unreviewed model output under your name. Skip it if you freeze when a number cannot be confirmed. Skip it if you would rather build the whole project than recommend a next step. Scope creep into doing the work is how a \$300 brief becomes a \$3,000 job you forgot to price.

If you cannot yet name three people who already ask you for this kind of help, this is not your first path. Do a productized service or a playbook in a job you know, then offer briefs to the same people.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this on the order form: “48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$[price]. One revision included.”

That is the whole offer. If you cannot fit it on a sticky note, you are selling a retainer.

What is in - Intake: the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried. - A sweep with a model. - Your verification pass against sources you named in advance. - Two pages delivered in 48 hours from a complete intake, not from the first vague email. - One revision window of 48 hours after delivery. Revision means clarify or correct, not “now also write the strategy deck.”

What is out Building the thing. Sitting in their Slack. Monitoring a topic for a month. Interviews you did not quote in the scope. If they need those, that is a different package with a different number.

What done looks like

Done is a two-page file the buyer can forward without you on the call. It has a recommended next step that a human could take this week. It has a “do not know” section that is specific, not theatrical. Sources that are stated as fact have been opened by you. The clock was kept.

The page-one test Hand the brief to someone who does not know the buyer. In three minutes they should be able to say: the decision, the recommendation, the biggest uncertainty. If they cannot, you wrote an essay.

Delivery, done - PDF or Doc they own, in their inbox, inside 48 hours of a complete intake. - Filename with the topic and the date, not “brief_final_v3.” - One revision if they ask inside the window. Then the job is closed unless they buy another brief.

Pricing

The cash window is \$150–\$600 per brief. Robin sells at \$300. That is the number to copy until you have proof you are slow or uniquely sourced.

How to pick the number - \$150 if this is your first paid brief, the topic is one you already know, and you need a case. Discount once. Then lock the fee. - \$300 for a standard 48-hour, two-page, one-revision brief with named sources. Default. - \$450–\$600 if they need you to include a small set of primary documents they provide (filings, a competitor’s pricing page, a contract clause) and the decision is time-sensitive inside their week.

Do not charge hourly. A slow reader should not earn more than a fast one for the same two pages. Do not charge \$50. That price buys a paste, and they will treat it like one.

Rush and extras Rush under 24 hours: add 50 percent, and only if you actually have the hours. A second topic is a second brief, not a longer first one. A monthly “keep an eye on this” is a retainer you should not sell until five briefs have landed on time.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a website. You need a template, a fee, and three people who already ask you what to do.

Hour 1–4: the brief template Open a two-page Doc with locked headings:

Decision on the table

What I found

What I verified (with sources)

What I do not know

Recommended next step

One thing I would not do

Write a one-paragraph sources policy under the template: sites you will use, sites you will not, and the rule that an unchecked number is not a fact. If you will not use Reddit as a source, say so. If a trade journal is in, say so.

Hour 5–8: the order form Five fields only: name, email, the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried. Price on the form. \$300. Payment before you start the clock. 48 hours starts when intake is complete and the payment is in, whichever is later.

Day 2–3: three offers Send the sentence to three people who already lean on you. Not a cold list. “I turned the way I already help you into a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. If you have a decision this month, I’ll take one.”

Deliver the first even if you discount it to \$150 to get a case. Deliver on time. Then lock the price. A late free brief teaches the wrong lesson.

The path, step by step

Do these in order. The clock is part of the product.

Write the two-page template and the sources policy. If you cannot name sources you refuse, you are not ready to charge for verification.

Put \$300 on a one-page offer. Intake fields, turnaround, one revision, what is out. Payment link above the fold.

Ask three people who already ask you “what should I do about X?” Offer one discounted first seat if you need a sample, then never discount without a reason you can say out loud.

On a yes: collect payment, then the intake. Do not start on a voice note. Incomplete intake does not start the 48 hours.

Sweep with a model. Prompt it for a map: claims, names, numbers, competing views. Dump that into a working doc you will not send.

Verify. Open the sources. Check the numbers. Kill anything you cannot confirm. Move the rest to “do not know” or cut it.

Write two pages in your voice. Short sentences. The recommendation sits near the top, not after a tour of the landscape.

Fill “do not know” with specifics: “I could not find 2025 market share from a primary filing. Vendor blogs claim 18 percent. Treat as unverified.”

Deliver inside 48 hours as a file they own. Restate the revision window in the email.

If they revise, you clarify or correct. You do not add a second question. If they want the second question, sell brief two.

After delivery, ask one thing: which sentence they used. That sentence becomes your next outbound line.

After three on-time briefs, raise from \$150 (if you discounted) to \$300, or from \$300 to \$450 if demand is real and your calendar is full. Do not raise because you feel fancy.

A worked example: Robin's \$300 brief

Robin helps independent clinic owners who keep asking whether they should buy a new scheduling tool. Robin is not a software vendor. Robin has sat through four of these decisions in

two years and is tired of rewriting the same email.

The offer Robin sent Wednesday morning, Robin messages three clinic owners: “48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision. Clock starts when I have the decision, the deadline, and payment.”

One replies. Decision: stay on the current scheduler or move to Tool B before October 1, because two front-desk people just gave notice. They already tried a vendor demo and a Facebook group thread. They pay \$300 Thursday at 9:12am. Intake is complete at 9:40. Clock ends Saturday 9:40am.

How Robin actually works Thursday, Robin uses a model to sweep: feature lists, pricing pages, two complaint patterns, HIPAA claims. That dump is ugly and stays private. Then Robin opens sources. Pricing is confirmed on both vendor pages, screenshots dated. A “HIPAA compliant” badge on Tool B’s homepage is marketing copy; Robin cannot find a BAA sample without a sales call, so that goes in “do not know.” A Reddit thread claiming Tool B lost appointments for a 200-provider group is one anonymous post — not a fact. Cut.

Robin writes two pages, not seven. Page one: the decision, the recommendation (stay through October, run a 14-day parallel on Tool B with one provider, do not cut over during staffing loss), the three verified differences that matter for a two-person front desk. Page two: sources, the “do not know” block, one thing Robin would not do (sign an annual on a sales call this week).

The “do not know” section, copied - Cannot verify Tool B’s uptime for 2025 from a primary status page; vendor says “99.9 percent” on a marketing URL only. - Cannot confirm BAA language without a sales call. If HIPAA is the reason to switch, that call is the next step, not a cutover. - No independent review of Tool B’s SMS reminders in this state. Vendor blog only.

Saturday 8:10am, the PDF lands. Filename: “Scheduler-stay-or-move_brief_18Apr.pdf.” Revision window until Monday 8:10. The owner asks one clarifying question: what “parallel” means in

hours. Robin adds four sentences. Job closed. \$300. Time on the clock: about five hours of real work, two of them verification.

Robin does not offer to implement the parallel. That would be a project. Robin notes the case, locks the fee at \$300, and does not write a twelve-page version “to be thorough.”

Copy you can actually send

Use these. Swap the topic. Do not add a biography.

The outbound line 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300.

The DM or email You keep asking me what to do about [X]. I turned that into a fixed job: 48-hour brief, two pages, sources checked, a “do not know” section so we do not pretend. \$300, one revision. If you have a decision this month, I’ll take one.

The order-form headline A messy question in. A two-page brief out. Clock starts when intake and payment are both in.

The delivery email Attached: two-page brief on [decision]. I verified the items in section 3. Section 4 is what I still do not know — please do not treat those as facts. Recommended next step is on page one. One revision if you send it within 48 hours. After that, a new brief is a new order.

What you do not write “AI knows everything.” “Comprehensive report.” “I’ll keep looking until you are happy.” Those sentences are how you work for free and ship fiction.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1 Day 1: template plus sources policy plus \$300 form. Days 2–3: three offers. Day 4–7: deliver one on time, even if the first is \$150. Then lock the fee. Do not take a second brief until the first has landed.

Week 2 If the first buyer used a sentence, put that sentence in your next three asks. If they did not, ask what they needed that was missing — usually it is a clearer next step, not more pages. Ship that as a template change, not as unpaid extra work.

Week 3–4 Two more briefs at full price, or stop and pick a different path. Three on-time deliveries is enough proof. A monthly retainer is not the goal this month. Speed and a spine in the “do not know” section are the goal.

The quality bar

A brief is good when a skeptical reader can see the seam between verified and guessed.

Hard rules - If a number cannot be checked, it does not go in as fact. - If you will not use a source, say so in the policy, not after they complain. - Citations you did not open do not appear. Hallucinated citations are a firing offense you give yourself. - The recommendation is a verb plus an object plus a time: “Stay on Tool A through October 1. Run a 14-day parallel.” Not “consider exploring options.”

Length Two pages. A third page is a failure of editing unless they paid for a document dump they provided. Do not “add value” with appendices they will not read.

Voice Kitchen table. No hype. You may be wrong in the recommendation. You may not be fuzzy. Wrong and clear can be revised. Vague cannot.

What to count

Per brief - Hours from complete intake to send. Target: under 48, usually 4–8 hours of work inside that window. - Sources opened versus sources the model proposed. If you opened fewer than half, you are not verifying. - Whether they used the next step inside two weeks. A yes is a case. A no is a template problem or a bad-fit buyer.

After five briefs On-time rate. Aim for 5/5. One late brief is a process bug; three is you selling a clock you do not keep. Average fee. If you are still at \$150 after five, you are discounting as a personality trait. Revision count. If every job uses the revision to add a second question, your intake is soft. Tighten the form.

Ignore how clever the model sounded in the sweep. Nobody paid for that dump.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“Can’t they just ask ChatGPT?” They can. They will still have to check it. You are selling the check, the cut, and a next step they can defend in a meeting. If they want the paste, they should not hire you.

“Two pages feels thin for \$300.” Twelve pages they will not read is thinner. Price the decision, not the paper weight. Robin’s clinic owner forwarded one page-one paragraph to a partner. That is use.

“I might miss something.” You will. That is why “do not know” exists. Missing something and labeling it is professional. Missing something and stating it as fact is how this path dies.

“They want me to just hop on a call.” A call without a brief becomes the whole job, unpaid. Offer the brief. If they want a 20-minute walkthrough after delivery,

price it as \$75 or include once, in writing. Do not let the call replace the file.

“What if they want the whole project?” Say no, or sell a different package. A brief that turns into implementation without a new quote is how you train them to ignore your scope.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Briefs sit next to other operator paths. They are not a funnel slide.

What feeds a brief practice People who already ask you for judgment: clients from a productized service, readers of a newsletter, buyers of a playbook who now have a live decision. Cold traffic can work later. First sales come from three names you can text.

What a brief feeds - A productized service, if the next step is work they want you to do. New quote. New scope. - A playbook, if three briefs repeat the same structure. The template becomes a \$19–\$47 file. - Custom project setups, if the recommendation is “configure the tool,” not “I will configure it this afternoon for free.” - Trust for a later retainer you still should not sell in week one.

Do not use a brief as a bait-and-switch into a \$5,000 project they did not ask for. Recommend. Then wait to be asked.

Mistakes that kill this path

Hallucinated citations. Briefs that refuse to recommend. Scope creep into doing the whole project. Those three still kill it.

The rest - Starting the clock on a vague email. - Delivering twelve pages to look serious. - Leaving “do not know” empty because it felt like weakness. - Publishing the brief as a public post with the client’s numbers in it. - Claiming

the model “knows everything.” - A second revision, then a third, because you did not close the window. - Undercharging at \$49 so you feel like you can be sloppy.

If you catch yourself pasting a URL you did not open into a footnotes list, stop and delete the line. That is the whole ethic in one reflex.

Tools — only what you need

Writing and delivery Google Docs or Word. Export PDF. Their inbox. That is enough. Notion is optional and often slower.

Intake and pay A Tally or Google Form. Stripe Payment Link. \$300. You do not need a proposal tool for a two-page product.

Research The model you already pay for, used as a sweep. A browser. The actual source pages. A folder of dated screenshots for numbers that might move. A simple rule list of sources you will and will not use.

Do not add yet Do not buy a “research agent” stack, a scraping farm, or a CRM. Three clients do not need a pipeline. They need you to open the links.

Checklist

Two-page template with the six headings, including “do not know”

Sources policy written: in, out, unchecked numbers are not facts

Offer sentence on one page: 48 hours, two pages, \$300, one revision

Intake: decision, deadline, what they already tried

Payment before the clock

Clock starts only when intake is complete and payment is in

Model for sweep, private dump, never sent

Every fact opened at the source

Recommendation is a verb, an object, and a time

Filename has topic and date

Delivered inside 48 hours

Revision window restated in the email

Second question = second brief

After delivery: one sentence they used, written down

First discount, if any, is once. Then the fee is locked

FAQ

Why 48 hours and not a week? A week becomes a research project. 48 hours forces a decision-sized file. If they need a week of interviews, that is not this product.

What if intake arrives at 6pm Friday? State your working days on the form. “48 hours on business days” is allowed if you write it before they pay. Do not surprise them with Monday math after a Friday charge unless the form said so.

Do I show my working? No. They get two pages. The sweep dump stays yours. Showing the raw model output trains them to skip you next time.

Can I use the brief as public content? Not with their numbers, names, or quotes, unless they said yes in writing. You may rewrite a generic version weeks later if nothing identifying remains.

What if I cannot verify the key number? Put it in “do not know.” Change the recommendation so it does not depend on a fake number. That section is why they trust you.

Is \$300 too high if I only spend four hours? No. They are buying the turnaround, the cut, and the nerve to recommend. If four hours feels guilty, look at the value of the decision, not your typing speed.

Should I offer unlimited email follow-up? No.
One revision. Then a new brief or a different path.

What if they want citations in academic form? Give enough to reopen the source: title, publisher, date, URL. You are not submitting a journal article. You are making a decision defensible.

Can I do this without a niche? You can try. You will be slower and worse. Start where you already know which sources lie.

When do I raise the price? After three on-time briefs at the current fee, if you are turning work away or the decisions are heavier. Not after one compliment.